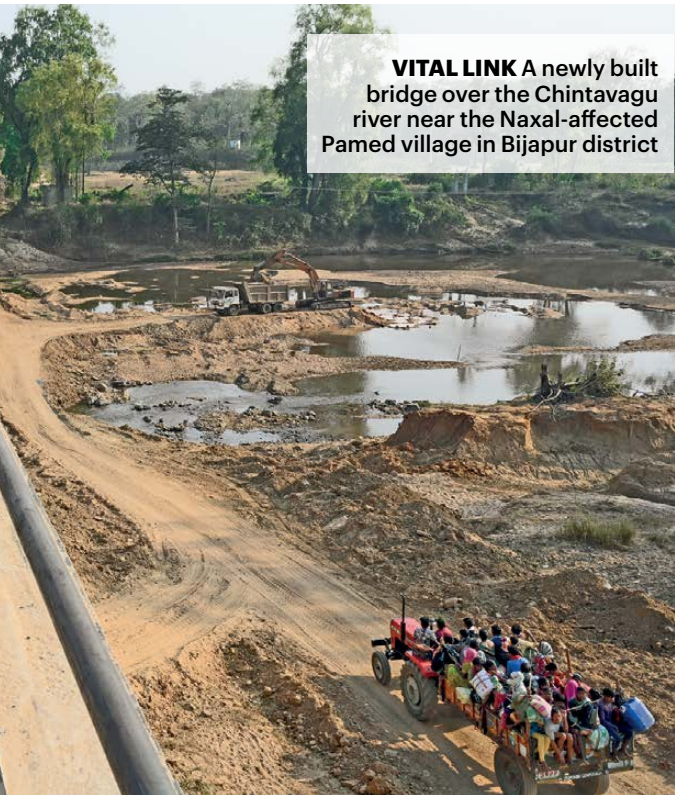


VITAL LINK A newly built bridge over the Chintavagu river near the Naxal-affected Pamed village in Bijapur district

IN CHHATTISGARH

IMPROVING CONNECTIVITY

ROADS

- The Road Connectivity Project for LWE-affected Areas has seen 49 roads (238 km) and nine bridges built in Chhattisgarh since January 2024
- Another 550 km roads repaired under PM Gram Sadak Yojana (Rs 100 cr.)
- Eighteen unfinished road projects (204 km) completed with the help of security forces

MOBILE TOWERS

- In the same period, 574 mobile towers installed, 325 upgraded to 4G
- Those installed include 125 under the LWE Phase 2 backed by Digital Bharat Nidhi, 87 under the Aspirational District Scheme and 362 under the 4G Saturation Scheme

Source: MHA

one on February 9 when 31 Naxals of the National Park Area Committee were killed in a gunfight.

Meanwhile, in what could be termed a Guns and Gulab (roses) policy, the Centre has upped its efforts to bring speedy development to Naxal-affected districts. The lack of development and exploitation of farmers by both contractors and government officers is seen as a root cause of the Naxalite movement flourishing in these zones. In a clever move, the FOBs are serving not just a security purpose but are also an integral part of the strategy to win the hearts and minds of the locals. On March 2, the Puvarti camp organised a Civic Action Programme (CAP) under which IGP Agarwal distributed bicycles, sarees, water tanks, blankets and medicines. Like other FOBs, Puvarti also has a 10-bed field hospital (FH), one of the six in the region, with a rudimentary operation theatre to cater to the medical needs of the locals.

A PANACEA CALLED DEVELOPMENT

Aware that minimising the security vacuum area is one aspect of dealing with the problem, there is also a thrust on addressing development deficiencies. A spanking new bridge constructed on the Chintavagu river near Pamed in Bijapur district is one of the many such civil infrastructure projects bringing much-needed connectivity to many villages. Never mind that the Naxals have made several attempts to blow up the bridge with explosives and attack the nearby Dharmavaram FOB. "The bridge has helped us access health services and also to find work as chilli pluckers in Pamed," says Markam Bandi, a resident of village Kanchal. Similarly, in areas that require roads but where the labour or contractors are unwilling to work, the home ministry has roped in the BRO to build them. Meanwhile, to improve communications, more than 2,000 mobile towers have been erected close to the FOBs. All this is being done to ensure that, as Shah says, "there is no reason for people to go back to Naxalism."

The Chhattisgarh government, too, is ramping up its civilian administration's response to the Naxal problem. With tendu leaf-plucking a major economic activity in the affected region, the state government has hiked the wages per standard bag from Rs 4,000 to Rs 5,500. The Niyad Nellanar or My Ideal Village scheme has been launched in affected areas under which residents are being enrolled for 52 schemes and 31 citizen services (see *Winning Hearts in Chhattisgarh*). The security camps play a crucial role in implementing schemes that include ration cards, cooking gas and cycles. All the key security agencies fighting the Naxals know it is a tough ask to meet the home minister's March 2026 deadline, but are determined to win the war.

Back in Puvarti, the CRPF camp is being decorated with party lights, chairs and tables are being arranged and sound systems readied for what seem like preparations for an upcoming dinner party. It's time for the *Bada Khana*—a tradition in the armed forces where officers and other ranks eat together on special occasions to mark a spirit of collective camaraderie. The celebrations are kickstarted with officers and jawans performing solo numbers. Dr Vivekanand Basappa, the camp medical officer, belts out the popular Kishore Kumar song—*Neele neele ambar par* (In the Blue Sky), as jawans join in, clapping to the beat. There is hope that the dark night of Naxal violence will end soon, and they, along with the rest of the country, will enjoy the clear blue skies of peace. ■